many years of solo wanderings, the Chinese scholar does not appear to have ever been robbed or cheated. This cannot be said of foreign travellers who visited India in subsequent centuries. Later visitors like Xuan Zang and Ibn Batuta would all have to face armed bandits. Even today, backpacking alone like Fa Xian can be unsafe for a foreigner in many parts of the country.

The Gupta emperors invested heavily in intellectual and artistic excellence. It was under their rule that the astronomer-mathematician Aryabhatta worked out that the earth was spherical and that it rotated on an axis. He argued that the phases of the moon were due to the movement of shadows and that the planets shone through reflected light. He even worked out a remarkably accurate estimate of the circumference of the earth and of the ratio Pi. All this a thousand years before Copernicus and Galileo.

Not far from his capital Pataliputra, Emperor Kumaragupta founded Nalanda University, which would go on to become a world-renowned hub for Buddhist studies. Further west, the Guptas established a secondary capital in Ujjain. The city not only became an important commercial node in the Southern Road but also an important centre of learning for the Hindu tradition. It was probably here that Kalidasa, often called India's Shakespeare, composed his famous works. Ujjain is today a small town in Madhya Pradesh, undistinguished except for a number of ancient temples. In the fifth century AD, however, it was a lively hub of commercial and intellectual exchange. Late on a monsoon night, when the cool moist breeze blows, it is still possible to imagine Kalidasa composing the *Meghdoota*, the Messenger of the Clouds.

So what was it like to visit one of these cities? Fa Xian tells us that cities of the Gangetic plains were exceptionally large and prosperous.[16] When he visited Pataliputra, he saw the ruins of Ashoka's palace that still stood in the middle of the city after six centuries. He was so impressed by the sheer scale of the stone walls, towers and doorways that he declared that they could not have been built by human hands—they must be the work of supernatural creatures.

While in Pataliputra, he witnessed a festival where the people built gigantic four-wheel wagons and then erected towers on them that were five